



The fisherman obeyed, but not without notching his cutlass. When the ash was cut and fashioned into the shape of a lever, the three men penetrated into the vault.

‘Stop where you are,’ said Monk to the fisherman. ‘We are going to dig up some powder; your light may be dangerous.’

The man drew back in a sort of terror, and faithfully kept to the post assigned him, whilst Monk and Athos turned behind a column at the foot of which, penetrating through a crack, was a moonbeam, reflected exactly on the stone which the Comte de la Fère had come so far in search.

‘This is it,’ said Athos, pointing out to the general the Latin inscription.

‘Yes,’ said Monk.

Then, as if still willing to leave the Frenchman one means of evasion,—‘Do you not observe that this vault has already been broken into,’ continued he, ‘and that several statues have already been knocked down?’

‘My lord, you have, without doubt, heard that the religious respect of your Scots loves to confide to the statues of the dead the valuable objects they have possessed during their lives. Therefore, the soldiers had reason to think that under the pedestals of the statues which ornament most of these tombs, a treasure was hidden. They have consequently broken down pedestal and statue: but the tomb of the venerable cannon, with which we have to do, is not distinguished by any monument. It is simple, therefore it has been protected by the superstitious fear which your Puritans have always had of sacrilege. Not a morsel of the masonry of this tomb has been chipped off.’

‘That is true,’ said Monk.

Athos seized the lever.

‘Shall I help you?’ said Monk.

‘Thank you, my lord; but I am not willing that your honour should lend your hand to a work of which, perhaps, you would not take the responsibility if you knew the probable consequences of it.’

Monk raised his head.

‘What do you mean by that, monsieur?’

‘I mean—but that man—’

‘Stop,’ said Monk; ‘I perceive what you are afraid of. I shall make a trial.’ Monk turned towards the fisherman, the whole of whose profile was thrown upon the wall.

‘THIS, THEN, IS THE SLAB?’

‘Come here, friend!’ said he in English, and in a tone of command.

The fisherman did not stir.

‘That is well,’ continued he: ‘he does not know English. Speak to me, then, in English, if you please, monsieur.’

‘My lord,’ replied Athos, ‘I have frequently seen men in certain circumstances have sufficient command over themselves not to reply to a question put to them in a language they understood. The fisherman is perhaps more learned than we believe him to be. Send him away, my lord, I beg you.’

‘Decidedly,’ said Monk, ‘he wishes to have me alone in this vault. Never mind, we shall go through with it; one man is as good as another man; and we are alone. My friend,’ said Monk to the fisherman, ‘go back up the stairs we have just descended, and watch that nobody comes to disturb us.’ The fisherman made a sign of obedience. ‘Leave your torch,’ said Monk; ‘it would betray your presence, and might procure you a musket-ball.’

The fisherman appeared to appreciate the counsel; he laid down the light, and disappeared under the vault of the stairs. Monk took up the torch, and brought it to the foot of the column.

‘Ah, ah!’ said he; ‘money, then, is concealed under this tomb?’

‘Yes, my lord; and in five minutes you will no longer doubt it.’

At the same time Athos struck a violent blow upon the plaster, which split, presenting a chink for the point of the lever. Athos introduced the bar into this crack, and soon large pieces of plaster yielded, rising up like rounded slabs. Then the Comte de la Fère seized the stones and threw them away with a force that hands so delicate as his might not have been supposed capable of having.

‘My lord,’ said Athos, ‘this is plainly the masonry of which I told your honour.’

‘Yes, but I do not yet see the casks,’ said Monk.

‘If I had a dagger,’ said Athos, looking round him, ‘you should soon see them, monsieur. Unfortunately, I left mine in your tent.’

‘I would willingly offer you mine,’ said Monk, ‘but the blade is too thin for such work.’

Athos appeared to look around him for a thing of some kind that might serve as a substitute for the weapon he desired. Monk did not lose one of

‘On the contrary, monsieur, they will assist in rolling out the barrels, if your honour will permit them.’

‘You are right.’

The post, though fast asleep, roused up at the first steps of the three visitors amongst the briars and grass that invaded the porch. Monk gave the password, and penetrated into the interior of the convent, preceded by the light. He walked last, watching the least movement of Athos, his naked dirk in his sleeve, and ready to plunge it into the back of the gentleman at the first suspicious gesture he should see him make. But Athos, with a firm and sure step, crossed the chambers and courts.

Not a door, not a window was left in the building. The doors had been burnt, some on the spot, and the charcoal of them was still jagged with the action of the fire, which had gone out of itself, powerless, no doubt, to get to the heart of those massive joints of oak fastened together with iron nails. As to the windows, all the panes having been broken, night birds, alarmed by the torch, flew away through their holes. At the same time, gigantic bats began to trace their vast, silent circles around the intruders, whilst the light of the torch made their shadows tremble on the high stone walls. Monk concluded that there could be no man in the convent, since wild beasts and birds were there still, and fled away at his approach.

After having passed the rubbish, and torn away more than one branch of ivy that had made itself a guardian of the solitude, Athos arrived at the vaults situated beneath the great hall, but the entrance of which was from the chapel. There he stopped. ‘Here we are, general,’ said he.

‘This, then, is the slab?’

‘Yes.’

‘Ay, and here is the ring—but the ring is sealed into the stone.’

‘We must have a lever.’

‘That’s a very easy thing to find.’

Whilst looking around them, Athos and Monk perceived a little ash of about three inches in diameter, which had shot up in an angle of the wall, reaching a window, concealed by its branches.

‘Have you a knife?’ said Monk to the fisherman.

‘Yes, monsieur.’

‘Cut down this tree, then.’

'Yes, your honour. Does it please your honour that I should accompany you?'

'You or another; it is of very little consequence, provided I have a light.'

'It is strange!' thought Athos; 'what a singular voice that man has!'

'Some fire, you fellows!' cried the fisherman; 'come, make haste!'

Then addressing his companion nearest to him in a low voice:—'Get ready a light, Menneville,' said he, 'and hold yourself ready for anything.'

One of the fishermen struck light from a stone, set fire to some tinder, and by the aid of a match lit a lantern. The light immediately spread all over the tent.

'Are you ready, monsieur?' said Monk to Athos, who had turned away, not to expose his face to the light.

'Yes, general,' replied he.

'Ah! the French gentleman!' said the leader of the fishermen to himself.

'Peste! I have a great mind to charge you with the commission, Menneville; he may know me. Light! light!' This dialogue was pronounced at the back of the tent, and in so low a voice that Monk could not hear a syllable of it; he was, besides, talking with Athos. Menneville got himself ready in the meantime, or rather received the orders of his leader.

'Well?' said Monk.

'I am ready, general,' said the fisherman.

Monk, Athos, and the fisherman left the tent.

'It is impossible!' thought Athos. 'What dream could put that into my head?'

'Go forward; follow the middle causeway, and stretch out your legs,' said Monk to the fisherman.

They were not twenty paces on their way when the same shadow that had appeared to enter the tent came out of it again, crawled along as far as the piles, and, protected by that sort of parapet placed along the causeway, carefully observed the march of the general. All three disappeared in the night haze. They were walking towards Newcastle, the white stones of which appeared to them like sepulchres. After standing for a few seconds under the porch, they penetrated into the interior. The door had been broken open by hatchets. A post of four men slept in safety in a corner, so certain were they that the attack would not take place on that side.

'Will not these men be in your way?' said Monk to Athos.

the movements of his hands, or one of the expressions of his eyes. 'Why do you not ask the fisherman for his cutlass?' said Monk; 'he has a cutlass.'

'Ah! that is true,' said Athos; 'for he cut the tree down with it.' And he advanced towards the stairs.

'Friend,' said he to the fisherman, 'throw me down your cutlass, if you please, I want it.'

The noise of the falling weapon sounded on the steps.

'Take it,' said Monk; 'it is a solid instrument, as I have seen, and a strong hand might make good use of it.'

Athos appeared only to give to the words of Monk the natural and simple sense under which they were to be heard and understood. Nor did he remark, or at least appear to remark, that when he returned with the weapon, Monk drew back, placing his left hand on the stock of his pistol; in the right he already held his dirk. He went to work then, turning his back to Monk, placing his life in his hands, without possible defence. He then struck, during several seconds, so skilfully and sharply upon the intermediary plaster, that it separated into two parts, and Monk was able to discern two barrels placed end to end, and which their weight maintained motionless in their chalky envelope.

'My lord,' said Athos, 'you see that my presentiments have not been disappointed.'

'Yes, monsieur,' said Monk, 'and I have good reason to believe you are satisfied; are you not?'

'Doubtless I am; the loss of this money would have been inexpressibly great to me: but I was certain that God, who protects the good cause, would not have permitted this gold, which should procure its triumph, to be diverted to baser purposes.'

'You are, upon my honour, as mysterious in your words as in your actions, monsieur,' said Monk. 'Just now as I did not perfectly understand you when you said that you were not willing to throw upon me the responsibility of the work we were accomplishing.'

'I had reason to say so, my lord.'

'And now you speak to me of the good cause. What do you mean by the words "the good cause?" We are defending at this moment, in England, five or six causes, which does not prevent every one from considering his own not only as the good cause, but as the best. What is yours, monsieur?'

Speak boldly, that we may see if, upon this point, to which you appear to attach a great importance, we are of the same opinion.'

Athos fixed upon Monk one of those penetrating looks which seemed to convey to him to whom they are directed a challenge to conceal a single one of his thoughts; then, taking off his hat, he began in a solemn voice, while his interlocutor, with one hand upon his visage, allowed that long and nervous hand to compress his moustache and beard, while his vague and melancholy eye wandered about the recesses of the vaults.

'As it is so,' said Monk, 'and we must have a light, a lantern, a torch, or something by which we may see where to see our feet; let us seek this light.'

'General, the first soldier we meet will light us.'

'No,' said Monk, in order to discover if there were not any connivance between the Comte de la Fère and the fisherman. 'No, I should prefer one of these French sailors who came this evening to sell me their fish. They leave to-morrow, and the secret will be better kept by them; whereas, if a report should be spread in the Scottish army, that treasures are to be found in the Abbey of Newcastle, my Highlanders will believe there is a million concealed beneath every slab, and they will not leave stone upon stone in the building.'

'Do as you think best, general,' replied Athos, in a natural tone of voice, making evident that soldier or fisherman was the same to him, and that he had no preference.

Monk approached the causeway behind which had disappeared the person he had taken for Digby, and met a patrol who, making the tour of the tents, was going towards headquarters; he was stopped with his companion, gave the password, and went on. A soldier, roused by the noise, unrolled his plaid, and looked up to see what was going forward. 'Ask him,' said Monk to Athos, 'where the fishermen are; if I were to speak to him, he would know me.'

Athos went up to the soldier, who pointed out the tent to him; immediately Monk and Athos turned towards it. It appeared to the general that at the moment they came up, a shadow like that they had already seen, glided into this tent; but on drawing nearer he perceived he must have been mistaken, for all of them were asleep *pele mele*, and nothing was seen but arms and legs joined, crossed, and mixed. Athos, fearing lest he should be suspected of connivance with some of his compatriots, remained outside the tent.

'*Hola!*' said Monk, in French, 'wake up here.' Two or three of the sleepers got up.

'I want a man to light me,' continued Monk.

'Your honour may depend on us,' said a voice which made Athos start. 'Where do you wish us to go?'

'You shall see. A light! come, quickly!'

belonging to Monk's army, which watched the enemy; it was composed of one hundred and fifty Scots. They had swum across the Tweed, and, in case of attack, were to recross it in the same manner, giving the alarm; but as there was no post at that spot, and as Lambert's soldiers were not so prompt at taking to the water as Monk's were, the latter appeared not to have as much uneasiness on that side. On this side of the river, at about five hundred paces from the old Abbey, the fishermen had taken up their abode amidst a crowd of small tents raised by soldiers of the neighbouring clans, who had with them their wives and children. All this confusion, seen by the moon's light, presented a striking coup d'œil; the half shadow enlarged every detail, and the light, that flatterer which only attaches itself to the polished side of things, courted upon each rusty musket the point still left intact, and upon every rag of canvas the whitest and least sullied part.

Monk arrived then with Athos, crossing this spot, illumined with a double light, the silver splendour of the moon, and the red blaze of the fires at the meeting of these three causeways; there he stopped, and addressing his companion, — 'Monsieur,' said he, 'do you know your road?'

'General, if I am not mistaken, the middle causeway leads straight to the Abbey.'

'That is right; but we shall want lights to guide us in the vaults,' Monk turned round.

'Ah! I thought Digby was following us!' said he. 'So much the better; he will procure us what we want.'

'Yes, general, there is a man yonder who has been walking behind us for some time.'

'Digby!' cried Monk. 'Digby! come here, if you please.'

But instead of obeying, the shadow made a motion of surprise, and, retreating instead of advancing, it bent down and disappeared along the jetty on the left, directing its course towards the lodging of the fishermen.

'It appears not to be Digby,' said Monk.

Both had followed the shadow which had vanished. But it was not so rare a thing for a man to be wandering about at eleven o'clock at night, in a camp in which are reposeing ten or eleven thousand men, as to give Monk and Athos any alarm at his disappearance.

Chapter XXVI

Heart and Mind

My lord,' said the Comte de la Fère, 'you are an noble Englishman, you are a loyal man; you are speaking to a noble Frenchman, to a man of heart. The gold contained in these two casks before us, I have told you was mine. I was wrong—it is the first lie I have pronounced in my life, a temporary lie, it is true. This gold is the property of King Charles II, exiled from his country, driven from his palaces, the orphan at once of his father and his throne, and deprived of everything, even of the melancholy happiness of kissing on his knees the stone upon which the hands of his murderers have written that simple epitaph which will eternally cry out for vengeance upon them:—"HERE LIES CHARLES I."'

Monk grew slightly pale, and an imperceptible shudder crept over his skin and raised his gray moustache.

'I,' continued Athos, 'I, Comte de la Fère, the last, only faithful friend the poor abandoned prince has left, I have offered him to come hither to find the man upon whom now depends the fate of royalty and of England; and I have come, and placed myself under the eye of this man, and have placed myself naked and unarmed in his hands, saying:—"My lord, here are the last resources of a prince whom God made your master, whom his birth made your king; upon you, and you alone, depend his life and future. Will you employ this money in consoling England for the evils it must have suffered from anarchy; that is to say, will you aid, and if not aid, will you allow King Charles II to act? You are master, you are king, all-powerful master and king, for chance sometimes defeats the work of time and God. I am here alone with you, my lord: if divided success alarms you, if my complicity annoys you, you are armed, my lord, and

here is a grave ready dug; if, on the contrary, the enthusiasm of your cause carries you away, if you are what you appear to be, if your hand in what it undertakes obeys your mind, and your mind your heart, here are the means of ruining forever the cause of your enemy, Charles Stuart. Kill, then, the man you have before you, for that man will never return to him who has sent him without bearing with him the deposit which Charles I, his father, confided to him, and keep the gold which may assist in carrying on the civil war. Alas! my lord, it is the fate of this unfortunate prince. He must either corrupt or kill, for everything resists him, everything repulses him, everything is hostile to him; and yet he is marked with divine seal, and he must, not to belie his blood, reascend the throne, or die upon the sacred soil of his country.”

‘My lord, you have heard me. To any other but the illustrious man who listens to me, I would have said: “My lord, you are poor; my lord, the king offers you this million as an earnest of an immense bargain; take it, and serve Charles II as I served Charles I, and I feel assured that God, who listens to us, who sees us, who alone reads in your heart, shut up from all human eyes,—I am assured God will give you a happy eternal life after death.” But to General Monk, to the illustrious man of whose standard I believe I have taken measure, I say: “My lord, there is for you in the history of peoples and kings a brilliant place, an immortal, imperishable glory, if alone, without any other interest but the good of your country and the interests of justice, you become the supporter of your king. Many others have been conquerors and glorious usurpers; you, my lord, you will be content with being the most virtuous, the most honest, and the most incorruptible of men: you will have held a crown in your hand, and instead of placing it upon your own brow, you will have deposited it upon the head of him for whom it was made. Oh, my lord, act thus, and you will leave to posterity the most enviable of names, in which no human creature can rival you.”’

Athos stopped. During the whole time that the noble gentleman was speaking, Monk had not given one sign of either approbation or disapprobation; scarcely even, during this vehement appeal, had his eyes been animated with that fire which bespeaks intelligence. The Comte de la Fère looked at him sorrowfully, and on seeing that melancholy countenance,

Chapter XXV

The Marsh



ATHOS and Monk passed over, in going from the camp towards the Tweed, that part of the ground which Digby had traversed with the fishermen coming from the Tweed to the camp. The aspect of this place, the aspect of the changes man had wrought in it, was of a nature to produce a great effect upon a lively and delicate imagination like that of Athos. Athos looked at nothing but these desolate spots; Monk looked at nothing but Athos—at Athos, who, with his eyes sometimes directed towards heaven, and sometimes towards the earth, sought, thought, and sighed.

Digby, whom the last orders of the general, and particularly the accent with which he had given them, had at first a little excited, Digby followed the pair at about twenty paces, but the general having turned round as if astonished to find his orders had not been obeyed, the aid-de-camp perceived his indiscretion, and returned to his tent.

He supposed that the general wished to make, incognito, one of those reviews of vigilance which every experienced captain never fails to make on the eve of a decisive engagement: he explained to himself the presence of Athos in this case as an inferior explains all that is mysterious on the part of his leader. Athos might be, and, indeed, in the eyes of Digby, must be, a spy, whose information was to enlighten the general.

At the end of a walk of about ten minutes among the tents and posts, which were closer together near the headquarters, Monk entered upon a little causeway which diverged into three branches. That on the left led to the river, that in the middle to Newcastle Abbey on the marsh, that on the right crossed the first lines of Monk’s camp; that is to say, the lines nearest to Lambert’s army. Beyond the river was an advanced post,

felt discouragement penetrate to his very heart. At length Monk appeared to recover, and broke the silence.

‘Monsieur,’ said he, in a mild, calm tone, ‘in reply to you, I will make use of your own words. To any other but yourself I would reply by expulsion, imprisonment, or still worse, for, in fact, you tempt me and you force me at the same time. But you are one of those men, monsieur, to whom it is impossible to refuse the attention and respect they merit; you are a brave gentleman, monsieur—I say so, and I am a judge. You just now spoke of a deposit which the late king transmitted through you to his son—are you, then, one of those Frenchmen who, as I have heard, endeavoured to carry off Charles I from Whitehall?’

‘Yes, my lord; it was I who was beneath the scaffold during the execution; I, who had not been able to redeem it, received upon my brow the blood of the martyred king. I received, at the same time, the last word of Charles; it was to me he said, “*Remember!*” and in saying, “*Remember!*” he alluded to the money at your feet, my lord.’

‘I have heard much of you, monsieur,’ said Monk, ‘but I am happy to have, in the first place, appreciated you by my own observations, and not by my remembrances. I will give you, then, explanations that I have given to no other, and you will appreciate what a distinction I make between you and the persons who have hitherto been sent to me.’

Athos bowed and prepared to absorb greedily the words which fell, one by one, from the mouth of Monk,—those words rare and precious as the dew in the desert.

‘You spoke to me,’ said Monk, ‘of Charles II; but pray, monsieur, of what consequence to me is that phantom of a king? I have grown old in a war and in a policy which are nowadays so closely linked together, that every man of the sword must fight in virtue of his rights or his ambition with a personal interest, and not blindly behind an officer, as in ordinary wars. For myself, I perhaps desire nothing, but I fear much. In the war of to-day rests the liberty of England, and, perhaps, that of every Englishman. How can you expect that I, free in the position I have made for myself, should go willingly and hold out my hands to the shackles of a stranger? That is all Charles is to me. He has fought battles here which he has lost, he is therefore a bad captain; he has succeeded in no negotiation, he is therefore a bad diplomatist; he has paraded his wants and his miseries in

all the courts of Europe, he has therefore a weak and pusillanimous heart. Nothing noble, nothing great, nothing strong has hitherto emanated from that genius which aspires to govern one of the greatest kingdoms of the earth. I know this Charles, then, under none but bad aspects, and you would wish me, a man of good sense, to go and make myself gratuitously the slave of a creature who is inferior to me in military capacity, in politics, and in dignity! No, monsieur. When some great and noble action shall have taught me to value Charles, I shall perhaps recognize his rights to a throne from which we cast the father because he wanted the virtues which his son has hitherto lacked, but, in fact of rights, I only recognize my own; the revolution made me a general, my sword will make me protector, if I wish it. Let Charles show himself, let him present himself, let him enter the competition open to genius, and, above all, let him remember that he is of a race from whom more will be expected than from any other. Therefore, monsieur, say no more about him. I neither refuse nor accept: I reserve myself—I wait.'

Athos knew Monk to be too well informed of all concerning Charles to venture to urge the discussion further; it was neither the time nor the place. 'My lord,' then said he, 'I have nothing to do but thank you.'

'And why, monsieur? Because you have formed a correct opinion of me, or because I have acted according to your judgment? Is that, in truth, worthy of thanks? This gold which you are about to carry to Charles will serve me as a test for him, by seeing the use he will make of it. I shall have an opinion which now I have not.'

'And yet does not your honour fear to compromise yourself by allowing such a sum to be carried away for the service of your enemy?'

'My enemy, say you? Eh, monsieur, I have no enemies. I am in the service of the parliament, which orders me to fight General Lambert and Charles Stuart—its enemies, and not mine. I fight them. If the parliament, on the contrary, ordered me to unfurl my standards on the port of London, and to assemble my soldiers on the banks to receive Charles II—'

'You would obey?' cried Athos, joyfully.

'Pardon me,' said Monk, smiling, 'I was going on—I, a gray-headed man—in truth, how could I forget myself? was going to speak like a foolish young man.'

'Then you would not obey?' said Athos.

Monk did not lose a single word. He was astonished either at the marvellous duplicity of this man and the superior style in which he played his part, or at the good loyal faith with which he presented his request, in a situation in which concerning a million of money, risked against the blow from a dagger, amidst an army that would have looked upon the theft as a restitution.

'Very well,' said he; 'I shall accompany you; and the adventure appears to me so wonderful, that I shall carry the torch myself.' And saying these words, he girded on a short sword, placed a pistol in his belt, disclosing in this movement, which opened his doublet a little, the fine rings of a coat of mail, destined to protect him from the first dagger-thrust of an assassin. After which he took a Scottish dirk in his left hand, and then turning to Athos, 'Are you ready, monsieur?' said he.

'I am.'

Athos, as if in opposition to what Monk had done, unfastened his poniard, which he placed upon the table; unhooked his sword-belt, which he laid close to his poniard; and, without affectation, opening his doublet as if to look for his handkerchief, showed beneath his fine cambric shirt his naked breast, without weapons either offensive or defensive.

'This is truly a singular man,' said Monk; 'he is without any arms; he has an ambuscade placed somewhere yonder.'

'General,' said he, as if he had divined Monk's thought, 'you wish we should be alone; that is very right, but a great captain ought never to expose himself with temerity. It is night, the passage of the marsh may present dangers; be accompanied.'

'You are right,' replied he, calling Digby. The aid-de-camp appeared. 'Fifty men with swords and muskets,' said he, looking at Athos.

'That is too few if there is danger, too many if there is not.'

'I will go alone,' said Monk; 'I want nobody. Come, monsieur.'